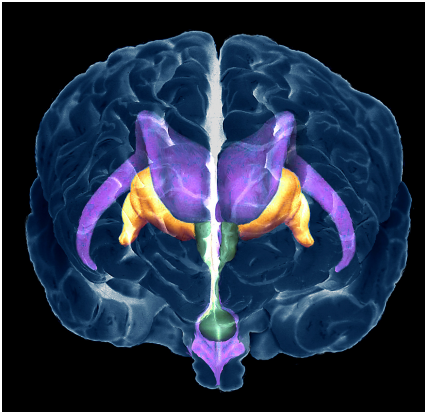




THIS IS **DAY 4 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
276 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

In this 3-D scan of the brain, the green central structure is the hypothalamus. This controls emotions and body temperature, and releases chemicals that regulate the release of hormones from the pituitary gland (green circle at bottom).

“ Like many women, you may sometimes feel ruled by your hormones, and it helps to understand why they fluctuate. ”

The hormone buildup to ovulation starts right now in week one of your menstrual cycle. Your pituitary gland, which lies in the base of your brain, produces the follicle-stimulating hormone (FSH). During your period, the level of FSH rises steadily, triggering the development of the follicles (around 15–20 each month) in each ovary. In addition to containing an egg, the follicles produce estrogen.

The hormone estrogen circulates, affecting the pituitary gland and causing it to produce luteinizing hormone (LH)—this triggers [ovulation](#). This week your estrogen levels are low and steady, but will rise dramatically later in your cycle.

Progesterone levels are low during your period, but start to rise several days afterward and stay high for the second part of the cycle. Under the influence of progesterone, the muscles in the cervix relax, easing open the cervical canal. Changes also affect the mucus, which becomes more fluid, so sperm find it easier to swim through. It is progesterone that enables the lining of the uterus to thicken in preparation for implantation of the fertilized egg.

Premenstrual syndrome (PMS) is one of the many symptoms women can get when their hormones fluctuate, but did you know that men get PMS too? Scientists have confirmed there's a male version of PMS—Irritable Male Syndrome. Mood swings, temper tantrums, and loss of libido in men were found to be caused by falling levels of testosterone due to stress.

ASK A DOCTOR

Will our chances of conceiving be affected by my partner being overweight and having high cholesterol? These two conditions, along with a resistance to insulin, high triglycerides, and high blood pressure, can reduce fertility. Advise your partner to have some checks done by their doctor if you are struggling to conceive, and seek the advice of a nutritionist.

CHANGES DURING THE MENSTRUAL CYCLE
